

FUNCTIONAL FOODS

Functional foods are foods that provide health benefits beyond basic nutrition. They contain biologically active components that help in disease prevention and health promotion.

Classification of Functional Foods

Naturally Functional Foods

Whole foods naturally rich in bioactive compounds

Example: fruits, vegetables, whole grains, nuts

Fortified / Enriched Foods

Foods with added nutrients

Example: iodized salt, fortified milk

Modified Functional Foods

Foods enhanced with beneficial components

Example: probiotic yogurt

Medical / Special Dietary Foods

Designed for specific health conditions

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Major Types of Functional Components

- Probiotics – Live beneficial microorganisms
- Prebiotics – Non-digestible food ingredients that stimulate good bacteria
- Synbiotics – Combination of probiotics and prebiotics
- Antioxidants – Vitamins C, E, beta-carotene
- Dietary Fiber
- Omega-3 fatty acids

Health Benefits

- Improve gut health
- Enhance immunity
- Reduce risk of cardiovascular diseases
- Help in diabetes management
- Prevent certain cancers
- Improve bone health